

Strategic Design Brief

A brief template that gets clients to hand over the information you actually need before a project starts.

WHO THIS IS FOR

Designers and studios who are tired of starting projects on vague instructions and finding out the real requirements three revisions in.

HOW TO USE IT

Send this to a client to fill out before kickoff, or fill it out together on a call. Don't start design work until every field has a real answer — "whatever looks good" is not an answer.

1. PROJECT BASICS

Client / business name

What are we designing? (be specific: logo, flyer, full identity, packaging, app UI...)

Deadline — and is it a real deadline (event, print date) or a soft one?

Budget range agreed

2. THE REAL OBJECTIVE

This is the section most briefs skip, and the one that saves the most revisions.

What should this design accomplish? (e.g. "get more walk-ins," "look credible to investors," "stand out on a crowded shelf")

How will you know it worked, after it's out in the world?

3. AUDIENCE

Who is this actually for? Describe one real person, not a demographic label.

What do they already think or feel about this brand, if anything?

4. DIRECTION & CONSTRAINTS

Brands, competitors, or references the client admires — and why

Anything the client has explicitly ruled out (colors, styles, comparisons to avoid)

Mandatory elements (logo lockup, legal text, tagline, existing brand colors)

5. DELIVERY

Where will this be used? (print, web, social, signage, packaging — list all)

Required file formats and sizes

Who has final sign-off? (name the actual decision-maker, not "the team")

BEFORE YOU START

If Section 2 is blank or vague, stop — go back to the client before opening any design software. A brief without a real objective produces revisions, not decisions.

NEXT STEPS

A strong brief is the cheapest insurance a design project has. Keep the filled-out version attached to the project file — when a client asks for a change late in the process, it's the fastest way to tell whether the request is a fix or a new project.